

75 Rehoboam

Solomon's son, who took the wrong advice and lost ten tribes in a single day.

Rehoboam was the son of Solomon and the first king of Judah after the kingdom divided. He came to the throne at forty-one, heir to the richest court Israel had known. The northern tribes asked him to lighten the heavy load his father had laid on them. He listened to his young friends instead of his father's older advisers and answered harshly. Ten tribes walked away and made Jeroboam I their king. Rehoboam spent the rest of his seventeen-year reign fortifying a smaller kingdom, drifting from God, and paying tribute to an Egyptian invader. Chronicles adds that he humbled himself when judgment came, and God eased his hand.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Rechavam</i> , often rendered "the people is enlarged"
Family	Son of Solomon and Naamah, an Ammonite woman (1 Kings 14:21)
Crowned	Age 41, c. 931 BC (1 Kings 14:21)
Reign	17 years in Jerusalem, c. 931–913 BC
Key places	Shechem, Jerusalem, the fortified cities of Judah
Key people	Jeroboam I, Shemaiah, Shishak of Egypt, his son Abijah
Main passages	1 Kings 12:1–24; 14:21–31; 2 Chronicles 10–12
New Testament	Named as "Roboam" in the genealogy of Jesus (Matthew 1:7)

"And he did evil, because he prepared not his heart to seek the LORD."

2 Chronicles 12:14, KJV

The life of Rehoboam

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the house chronology for the divided kingdom. Years are counted from the start of his reign.

c. 931 BC

Age 41

● Goes to Shechem

After Solomon's death, all Israel gathers at Shechem to make Rehoboam king. Jeroboam, back from Egypt, speaks for the tribes: ease the heavy yoke, and we will serve you. *1 Kings 11:43-12:5*

c. 931 BC

Three days later

● Rejects the elders

The old men who served Solomon urge him to serve the people. His young friends urge him to be harsher still. He takes their advice and threatens to chastise the tribes with scorpions. *1 Kings 12:6-15*

c. 931 BC

Soon after

● The kingdom splits

The northern tribes reject David's house. They stone Adoram, his taskmaster, and Rehoboam flees to Jerusalem by chariot. He musters 180,000 men for war, but Shemaiah tells him to stand down, and he obeys. *1 Kings 12:16-24*

c. 931-928 BC

Years 1-3

● Strengthens Judah

He fortifies cities across Judah and Benjamin. Priests and Levites from the north move south, and for three years the kingdom walks in the way of David and Solomon. *2 Chronicles 11:5-17*

c. 926 BC

5th year

● Shishak invades

Once secure, Rehoboam and Judah forsake God's law. Shishak of Egypt takes the fortified cities and strips the temple and palace, including Solomon's gold shields. The leaders humble themselves, and God spares Jerusalem. *1 Kings 14:25-28; 2 Chronicles 12:1-12*

c. 913 BC

Age 58

● Dies

After seventeen years marked by constant war with Jeroboam, he is buried in the city of David. His son Abijah reigns in his place. *1 Kings 14:29-31; 2 Chronicles 12:13-16*

Key activities

Kings tells the story of the split and Judah's sin. Chronicles adds his building, his large family, and his repentance when Shishak came.

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- 1 Went to Shechem to be crowned.** He went north to Shechem, the old meeting place of the tribes, where all Israel had gathered to make him king. *1 Kings 12:1*

 - 2 Asked for time and advice.** He sent the people away for three days and consulted both the old men and the young men. *1 Kings 12:5-11*

 - 3 Answered roughly.** He told the people, "my father made your yoke heavy, and I will add to your yoke." Ten tribes rebelled that day. *1 Kings 12:12-16*

 - 4 Obeyed the word to stand down.** When Shemaiah said, "this thing is from me," Rehoboam and his army went home instead of fighting. *1 Kings 12:21-24; 2 Chronicles 11:1-4*

 - 5 Built a line of fortresses.** He fortified Bethlehem, Lachish, Hebron and other towns, and stocked them with food, oil, wine, shields and spears. *2 Chronicles 11:5-12*

 - 6 Welcomed exiles from the north.** Priests, Levites and faithful people who rejected Jeroboam's calves came to Jerusalem to worship. *2 Chronicles 11:13-17*

 - 7 Built a large household.** He had eighteen wives and sixty concubines. He loved Maachah, Absalom's daughter, most and chose her son Abijah as heir. *2 Chronicles 11:18-23*

 - 8 Forsook the law.** Once strong, he and all Israel with him forsook God's law. Judah built high places and images on every high hill. *1 Kings 14:22-24; 2 Chronicles 12:1*

 - 9 Humbled himself.** When Shemaiah announced judgment through Shishak, the king and princes said, "The LORD is righteous." God granted them some deliverance. *2 Chronicles 12:5-7, 12*

 - 10 Replaced gold with brass.** He made brass shields to replace the gold ones Shishak had carried off. *1 Kings 14:26-28*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Rehoboam.

Old Testament

1 Kings 11:29–39	Ahijah foretells ten tribes torn from Solomon's son
1 Kings 12; 14:21–31; 2 Chronicles 10–12	The two main accounts
1 Kings 12:15	"The cause was from the LORD," fulfilling Ahijah's word
1 Kings 15:6	War with Jeroboam all their days
2 Chronicles 13:7	Abijah calls him "young and tenderhearted"
Echo: Proverbs 15:1	"A soft answer turneth away wrath"

New Testament

Matthew 1:7	"Roboam" in the royal line of Jesus
Echo: Mark 10:42–44	The great must be servants, as the elders advised

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did the older men advise, and what did the young men advise (1 Kings 12:6–11)?
2. *Understand:* The text says the split was Rehoboam's choice and also "from the LORD" (1 Kings 12:15, 24). How can both be true?
3. *Apply:* Whose advice do you tend to seek when you face a hard decision? Do they ever tell you what you would rather not hear?
4. *Apply:* Rehoboam drifted from God once he felt strong (2 Chronicles 12:1). What habit would keep you close to God in success?